

Overview & grading

How the Writing section works and how your texts are graded.

Total time	Tasks	Criteria	Tolerance
195 min	3 tasks (~250 words each)	4 × 0-10	±10%

THE WRITING SECTION

The BHS Writing section has **three tasks**, usually around 250 words each (each task states its own target, ±10%), and you get **195 minutes**. Writing is one of three sections of the written exam, alongside Reading and Listening – there is no separate Language in Use section. One BHS perk: (electronic) dictionaries are allowed, but only during the Writing section. The text types are article, report, blog, e-mail and leaflet – no essay.

Time split that works: three tasks in 195 minutes is roughly 55–60 minutes each, planning included. Read every prompt twice, note your finishing times on the task sheet, and keep about 15 minutes at the end to proofread all three.

At BHS, (electronic) dictionaries are allowed – but only during the Writing section, not in Reading or Listening. Even so, the tasks are built so that B2 vocabulary is enough; when a word will not come, paraphrase it.

THE TEXT TYPES AT BHS

Text type	Word count	Register	Title?	Key feature
Article	~250 words	Depends on the audience	Required – catchy!	Write for real readers
Report	~250 words	Formal, objective, neutral	Subject line + section headings	Present findings and recommend action
Blog	~250 words	Informal to semi-formal	Post only (not a comment)	Personal voice, invite interaction
E-mail	~250 words (225–275)	Usually formal	Required	Clear purpose, proper format
Leaflet	~250 words	Persuasive, reader-friendly	Required – plus subheadings	Inform and persuade at a glance

Word count tolerance: ±10%. Each task states its own target (usually around 250 words, so 225–275). If you are further off than that, Task Achievement is reduced by one band.

Almost every task gives three content points. Address each one in its own body paragraph, and follow whatever your task sheet actually lists. Register = how formal or casual your language is – the difference between a letter to a company and a message to a friend.

HOW YOU ARE GRADED: THE FOUR CRITERIA

Each text is rated with the official analytic scale: four independent criteria, each scored 0–10 and equally weighted – weaker areas can be compensated for by stronger ones. Level 6 is the B2 minimum in every criterion.

01 Task Achievement (Erfüllung der Aufgabenstellung)

All content points covered with supporting detail; text type conventions followed; appropriate title/greeting/closing; word count within ±10%.

02 Coherence and Cohesion (Kohärenz und Kohäsion)

Clear overall structure; effective paragraphing; logical development; variety of linking devices; clear relationships between sentences.

03 Lexical and Structural Range (Spektrum sprachlicher Mittel)

Variety of vocabulary and structures; complex sentence forms; not repeating the same phrases; appropriate register; not lifting from the prompt.

04 Lexical and Structural Accuracy (Sprachrichtigkeit)

Grammar control; correct word choice; spelling; punctuation; accurate use of linking devices.

VETO rule. If a text does not address the set task at all (an off-topic or clearly pre-prepared text that ignores the actual prompt), Task Achievement is rated 0 and the other three criteria are not assessed. Writing in the wrong text type alone does not trigger this. Read every task twice.

Don't play it safe with grammar. A text built only on simple sentences cannot reach the upper Range bands, even if every sentence is correct. Work in a passive, a conditional or a relative clause where it fits naturally.

WHAT THE BANDS MEAN (SIMPLIFIED)

10 • Excellent

Everything the task asks for, fully developed with well-chosen details. Conventions confidently used, wide range of vocabulary and complex structures, only occasional slips.

8 • Good

All content points developed with relevant details. Clear structure, good range and variety, errors are rare and never cause misunderstanding.

6 • B2 minimum met

This is the pass line of the official grid: all points developed but with limited supporting detail, a limited but appropriate set of linking devices, enough range including some complex forms, errors without damage to communication.

4 • Below B2

Content points addressed but not developed, mostly simple linear sentences, repetition and lifting from the prompt, or errors pile up beyond simple structures.

2 • Far below B2

Only parts of the task recognisable, very limited language, errors make parts of the text hard to understand.

0 • Not assessable / veto

No assessable performance – or the text fails to address the set task (see the VETO rule above).

Simplified from the official B2 rating scale (BMB, 2023 revision). The grid describes levels 0, 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10; the odd levels in between are for texts that sit between two descriptions. Your teachers grade with the full official scale.

THE 8 MOST EXPENSIVE MISTAKES

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
Writing only 2 of 3 bullet points	Task Achievement drops sharply	→ Tick off each bullet as you write it
Ignoring the text type's rules (e.g. a report without headings)	Task Achievement drops – conventions are part of the criterion	→ Check the Layout box in the guide before you start
Copying words from the prompt or the input material	Range drops – lifted language is not your language	→ Rephrase, then interpret: what does the figure mean for your point?
Word count off by more than $\pm 10\%$	Task Achievement drops one band	→ Count your words. Practise estimating.
Formal style in a blog (or vice versa)	Wrong register = lower Task Achievement	→ Ask: formal or informal? Then commit.
Only simple linking words	Low Coherence score	→ Use the B2 linking words table

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
No topic sentences	Paragraphs feel random, weak Coherence	→ First sentence of each paragraph = the point
Forgetting to proofread	Errors you would catch in 3 minutes	→ Always save 5-10 min at the end